ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

Meaning and Structure

University of Glasgow

From Clauses to Sentences

Marc Alexander

Week 4

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Identifying clause elements

(■ Predicators, ■ Subjects, ■ Objects, ■ Complements, ■ Adverbials)

Tam regards me sardonically for a moment as **I slam the door**, but **remains a very quiet fellow**. **I am becoming very hungry**. **Richie is providing the food from the plastic lunch box**, and **he gives me a sandwich**. **He swigs the Irn Bru** and **hands it to Tam**.

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What's left?!

(■ Predicators, ■ Subjects, ■ Objects, ■ Complements, ■ Adverbials)

Tam regards me sardonically for a moment as I slam the door, but remains a very quiet fellow. I am becoming very hungry. Richie is providing the food from the plastic lunch box, and he gives me a sandwich. He swigs the Irn Bru and hands it to Tam.

Conjunctions!

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Where Are We?

- Last week, we looked at how clauses contain phrases, and how those phrases have a *function* within a clause (Subject, Predicator, Object, Complement, Adverbial)
- Recap:
  - Phrase structure is about the *internal* structure of phrases (eg inside a NP, what functions as modifier, headword or neither?)
  - Clause structure is about how phrases *combine* in larger structures, such as sentences (eg is the NP functioning as the Subject or the Object of a clause?)

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The Levels of Grammar

(The 'Rank Scale')

- **Sentence:** Made up of main *clause(s)* plus possible subordinate *clause(s)*
- **Clause:** Made up of *phrases* acting as Subject/Predicator/Object/Complement/Adverbial
- **Phrase:** Made up of *words* acting as headwords or modifiers in a Noun Phrase/Verb Phrase/Prepositional Phrase/Adverb Phrase/etc.
- **Word:** Noun/Verb/Adjective/Preposition, etc.

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Okay, what is a clause?

- The key characteristic of a clause is that it *must* contain a VP functioning as Predicator
- We can think of clauses as being built up around Predicators; a clause is essentially a Predicator with its associated (optional) SOCA elements
  - Often, but by no means always, the basic structure is SPOC with As cropping up anywhere in between
- And the main thing about clauses is that they are the elements which make up a *sentence*

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How do clauses make sentences?

- Firstly, **simple sentences** are those which consist of one clause (ie, one Predicator)

He awoke in the night.

I love grammar.

Why do you hate me?

She really should go to the shops today.

The wolves will never stop hunting me.

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How do clauses make sentences?

- But not all sentences are simple; some contain more than one clause
- These are **compound** sentences and **complex** sentences
  - Compound sentences involve coordinating clauses together
  - Complex sentences involve clauses which are embedded inside other clauses

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Complex vs Compound

- Compound sentences use the **coordinating conjunctions** *and, or, but*, or *nor*
- Complex sentences have **main clauses** and **subordinate clauses**
  - Main clauses could be simple sentences, or parts of compound sentences
  - Subordinate clauses are embedded in a main clause, and can't stand on their own
  - They use subordinating conjunctions, such as *after, although, as, because, before, if, how, however, like, once, since, than, that, though, till, unless, until, when, where, while,* etc.
  - Subordinate clauses do the job of a clause element – that is, a subordinate clause can be a Subject, Object, Complement or Adverbial within a main clause – and some can work as modifiers inside a phrase

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Complex vs Compound

He **awoke** in the night and **discovered** he **loved** grammar.

I **loved** grammar when I first **read** about it.

I **love** grammar but I don't **love** my wife.

What you**'re saying** about grammar **is** awesome.

You **can kick** my dog, you **can insult** my family, you **can steal** my wine, but you **can't insult** grammar in my house.

Note the commas: coordinating conjunctions can be left out altogether (Leech calls this *unlinked coordination*). The commas here are doing the same job as *and*.

After we **learn** grammar, we **can take on** the world.

It **would be** a shame if sex and rock music **distracted** us from grammar.

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Decision Process

1. Count the Predicators
   - One Predicator? One clause: simple sentence
   - More than one Predicator? Look for *and, or, but, nor* (and for commas doing the same job as *and, or, but, nor*)
2. Check what the conjunction actually joins – words and phrases can be coordinated too
3. Test each clause on its own
   - If every one could stand alone: compound sentence
   - If **any one** cannot: it is subordinate and the sentence is complex

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Sentences and Clauses

- Simple sentence
  - One Predicator, one clause (must by definition be a main clause)
  - Bill is happy. He loves grammar. Luckily, he easily found similar friends.
- Compound sentence
  - Two+ Predicators, two+ main clauses, coordinating cj(s) (*and, or, but, nor*)
  - Bill is a grammarian and loves his job. He does grammar all day, but also has other interests like phonetics.
- Complex sentence
  - Two+ Predicators, one+ main clause(s), one+ subordinate clause(s) which act as SOCA, subordinating cj(s) (*because, although, unless, if, when, whilst, whether,* etc)
  - If a sentence contains both coordination and a subordinate clause, it is complex. A subordinate clause anywhere makes the whole sentence complex.
  - Because grammar makes him happy, Bill is content. He is never happier than he is when parsing sentences.

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Recognising Subordinate Clauses

- What if there is no subordinating conjunction?
- Look for non-finite verbs (see UGiST) such as *to go, going, having gone,* etc:
  - **Going to** the shops, I realised I had lost my puppy.
  - **To be** honest, I thought he was right next to me.
  - **Having lost** my puppy in Waitrose, I cried like a baby.
  - I was delighted **to see** my puppy again.
- Look for a wh- element (*who, whom, whose, what, which, when, where, how*) at the start of the clause:
  - **What you're saying about grammar** is awesome.
  - I know **which book you mean.**
  - The student **who sat at the front** asked a good question.

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Recognising Subordinate Clauses

- Subordinate clauses can be replaced by phrases which carry out the same clause function:

I told her about my lost puppy.
I told her the story.
I told her something.

Going to the shops, I realised I had lost my puppy.
That day, I realised I had lost my puppy.

To be honest, I thought he was right next to me.
Genuinely, I thought he was right next to me.

Having lost my puppy in Waitrose, I cried like a baby.
All day I cried like a baby.

I was delighted to see my puppy again.
I was delighted by it.

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Some Sentences


THE SCREEN IN REVIEW

Ten persons are isolated in a house on an island off the English coast.

Out of this lethal hocus-pocus, René Clair has produced an exciting film and has directed a splendid cast in it with humor and a light macabre touch.

While the score is quaintly tallied on a china centerpiece, the victims are clipped off like clockwork.

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Labelling Clauses

- Phrases get surrounded by round brackets (), clauses by square brackets [], sentences by squiggly brackets {}
- Main clause = MCl, subordinate clause = SCl
  - There are names for the subtypes of subordinate clause - see *UGiST*
- Coordinating conjunctions sit outside of clauses and phrases
- Subordinating conjunctions sit outside of phrases but inside the subordinate clause
- Sentence = Se

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Step 1: Label words

His	family	bought	a	house	there.
d	N	V	d	N	Av

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Step 2: Label headwords and modifiers

	M	H	H	M	H	H
His	family	bought	a	house	there.	
d	N	V	d	N	Av	

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Step 3: Round-bracket the phrases

	M	H		H		M	H		H
(His	family)		(bought)		(a	house)		(there.)	
	d	N		V		d	N		Av

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Step 4: Label the phrases for form

		M	H		H		M	H		H	
(His	family)			(bought)		(a	house)		(there.)		
NP	d	N		VP	V		NP	d	N	AvP	Av

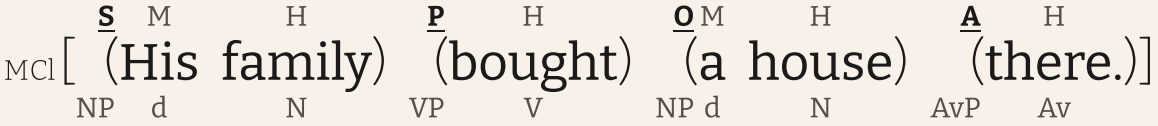
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Step 5: Label the phrases for function



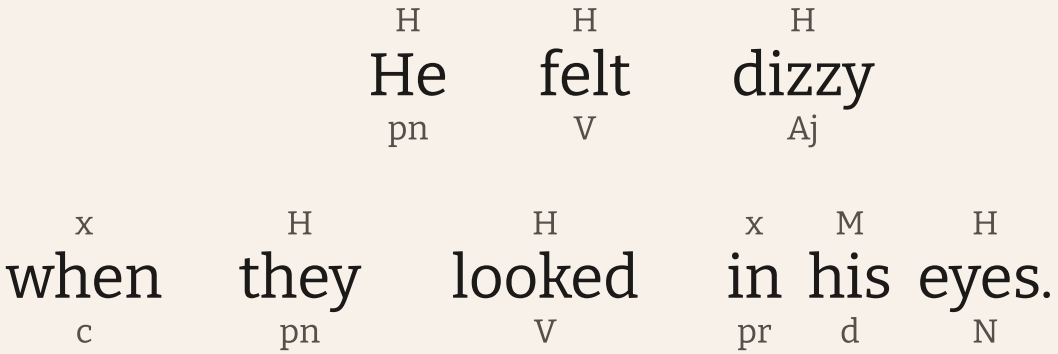
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Step 6: Label the clause



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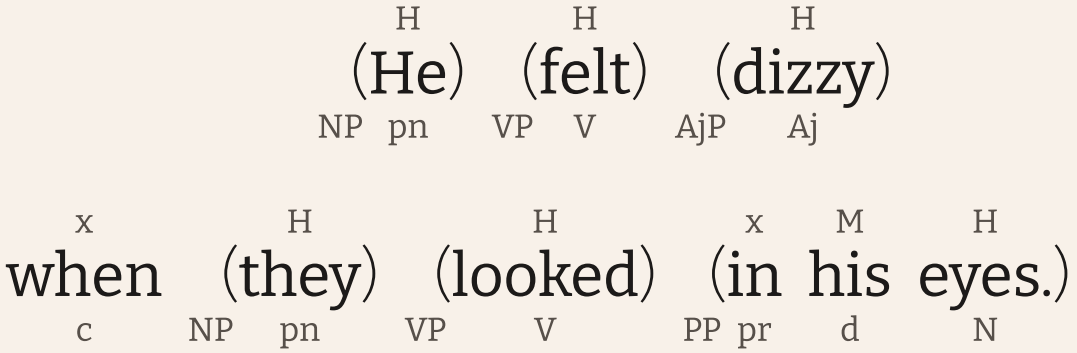
Step 1: Label the words



> Look out for conjunctions!

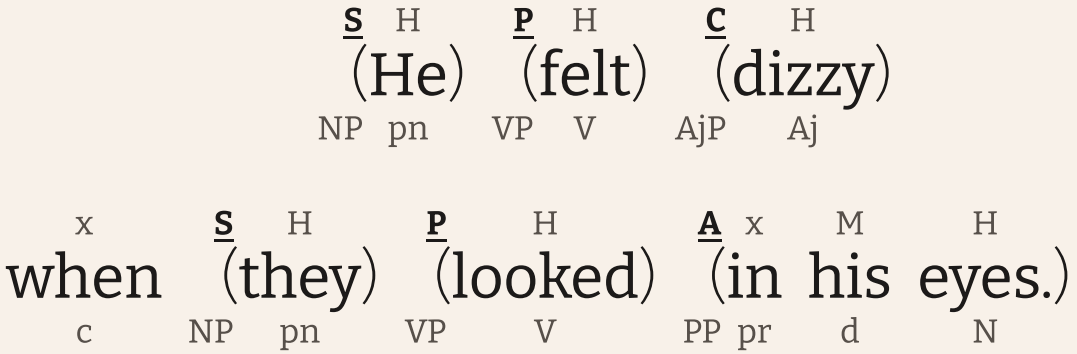
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Step 2: Label the phrases for form



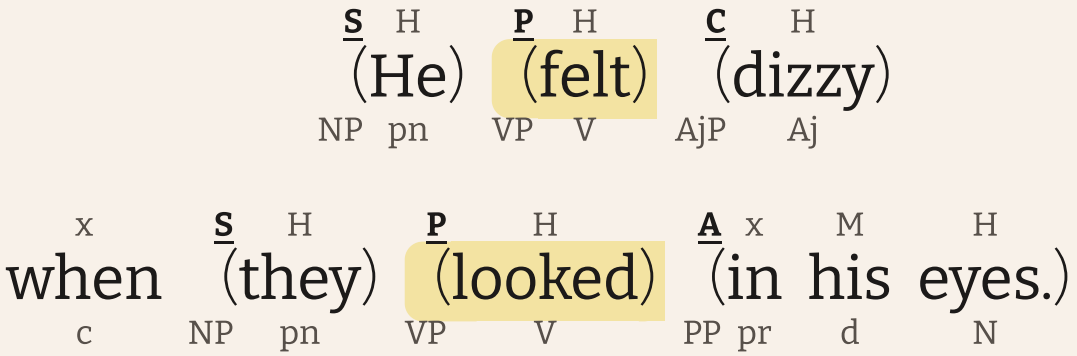
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Step 3: Label the phrases for function



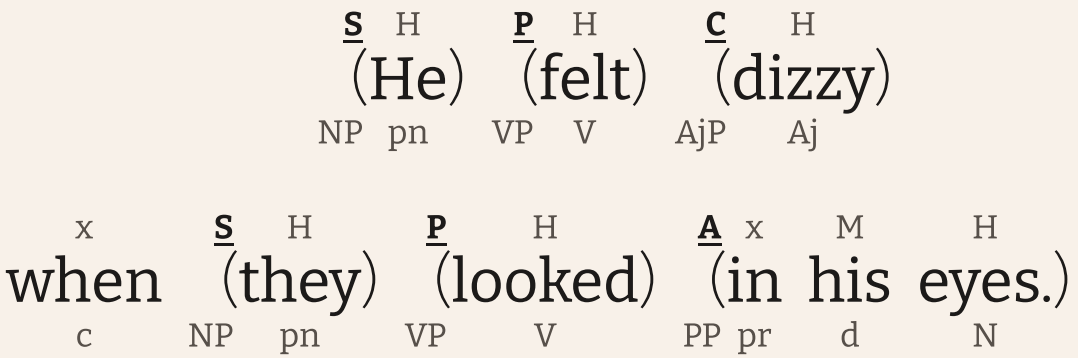
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Step 4: Count the Predicators!



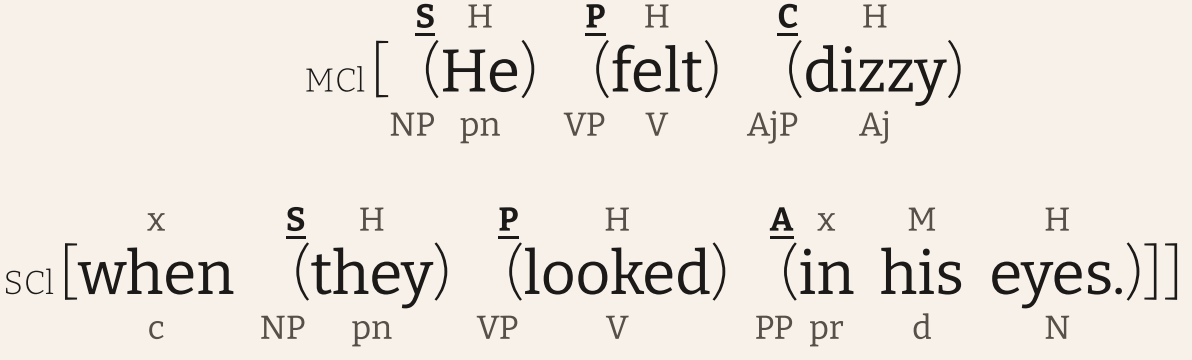
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Step 5: Identify the type of clauses



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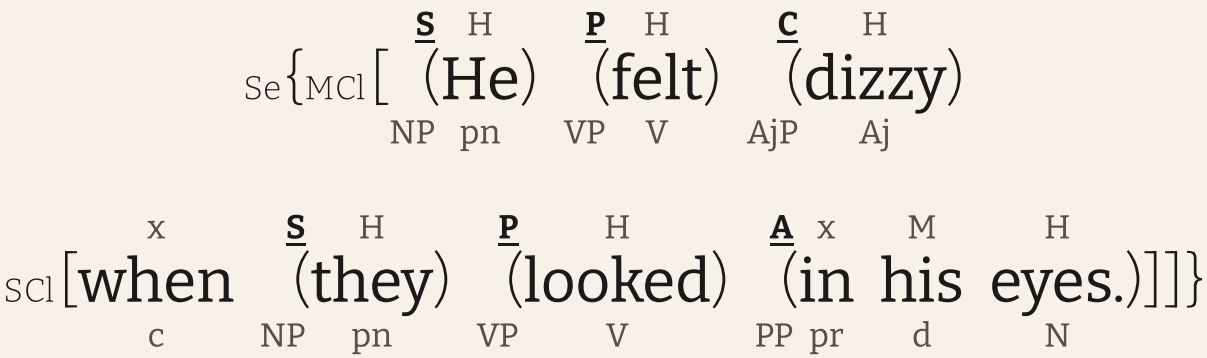
Step 6: Label the clauses



> Remember: subclauses go inside the main clause.

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Step 7: Label the sentence



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Simple and complex grammatical styles

Donald Barthelme: 'Edward and Pia'

Edward **looked** at his red beard in the tableknife. Then Edward and Pia **went** to Sweden, to the farm. In the mailbox, Pia **found** a check for Willie from the government of Sweden. It **was** for twenty-three hundred crowns **and had** a rained-on look. Pia **put** the check in the pocket of her brown coat. Pia **was** pregnant. In London she **had been** sick every day.

Eight Predicators, therefore eight clauses
In six simple sentences and one compound sentence

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Simple and complex grammatical styles

Henry James, *Washington Square*

> He **was** a thoroughly honest man – honest in a degree **of which** he **had** perhaps **lacked** the opportunity **to give** the complete measure; **and putting** aside the great good nature of the circle **in which** he **practised**, **which was** rather fond of **boasting that** it **possessed** the 'brightest' doctor in the county, he daily **justified** his claim to the talents **attributed** to him by the popular voice.

Ten Predicators, therefore ten clauses
In one complex sentence

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Simple and complex grammatical styles

- Different grammatical styles (simple and complex):
  - have different processing demands
  - have a different degree of formality
  - are associated with speech (simple) and writing (complex)
  - signal clause relationships differently

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The Levels of Grammar

(The 'Rank Scale')

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So what's left?

- Next week – the penultimate grammar lecture!
- What happens when the rank scale doesn't behave entirely normally…?
- *Rank-shift* (*subordination* and *embedding*), as well as another look at *substitution*, *ellipsis*, *particles*, and *phrasal verbs*.

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Follow-up

- You should now:
  - be up to Chapter 8 of *Understanding Grammar*, and again make sure to try the self-assessment Activities at the end of the chapters (answers at the back of the book).
  - have completed all the Units and the corresponding Exercises of the *English Grammar* site.
- If you have questions, talk to your tutor or do please come see me (details on Moodle)

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